

MBAi 420 Week 7: Define Phase

Feature: Mission-First Home

MVE Context

The MVE is focused on extending the core DoorDash product by orchestrating the gathering instead of just delivering its parts.

For a DoorDash customer hosting a Saturday gathering, we believe we can extend the core DoorDash product by organizing the platform around the gathering instead of individual stores. The MVE is not the full vision. It is the smallest version that lets users declare a party mission, see a curated multi-merchant cart, and tell us whether it worked. We know it is successful when party-mission carts drive a measurable lift in multi-merchant order completion and user-reported mission success. DoorDash is intentionally not doing natural language mission entry, ML-driven personalization, or AI-powered concierge experiences yet.

The first feature in the MVE is a lightweight mission declaration at the front door of the app. Users open DoorDash and tap a mission chip to declare what they are hosting. This captures structured mission intent at the entry point of the experience, which is the signal DoorDash does not have today.

Vision + Strategy

Vision:

DoorDash exists to grow local economies. We extend that mission by shifting from the delivery layer to the orchestrator that turns the things people are trying to accomplish into completed missions, powered by the local businesses that do them best.

Strategic logic:

The strategy is built around two reinforcing pillars: Mission Intelligence and Trust.

The more users delegate missions to DoorDash, the more first-party intent signal DoorDash captures about what users are trying to accomplish. The more intent signal DoorDash holds, the more reliably it can assemble and deliver missions users are willing to hand off again. Intelligence earns Trust. Trust generates more Missions. More Missions generate more Intelligence. Both pillars feed the same outcome: increase missions completed on DoorDash.

This feature ties directly to the vision of DoorDash becoming the orchestrator and to the strategic pillar of Mission Intelligence because it creates the entry point through which structured mission intent enters the platform. Today, order data tells DoorDash what users bought. Mission data tells DoorDash why. Without a mission-first entry point, the rest of the Mission Intelligence roadmap has no signal to operate on.

Feature Context

Feature:

Mission-First Home. A reframed home screen with mission chips that let users declare a hosting mission and route into a guided flow that ends in a curated multi-merchant cart.

What it does:

On app open, users see Mission-First Home in place of the store grid. They tap a mission chip (dinner, brunch, game day, cocktail night, casual gathering), confirm guest count, and confirm date. The system applies an ops-authored template scaled to the declared mission, assembles a multi-merchant cart, and routes the user to a single checkout.

Why this matters:

Users are already mission-driven shoppers. They research, plan, and orchestrate hosting across Instacart, Vivino, local florists, and specialty shops today. The mission exists before the app does. Today, users have to rebuild it every time. Mission-First Home is the place where the mission becomes a structured signal the platform can act on.

Where it may appear:

The feature is intended to appear at the front door of the app on open, with a fallback link to store browsing for users who came to the app for a different reason.

Product inspiration:

Instacart's Occasions feature reframes the store from inventory grid to mission anchor (game day, holiday dinner), and add-to-cart rates and basket sizes increase when the platform organizes around the user's goal rather than the store's catalog. Airbnb relaunched in 2025 as an AI-first travel and living concierge, where a single declared trip intent drives a unified experience pulling from Stays, Services, and Experiences. This is the same structural bet we are making: reframing the platform from a catalog of options to an orchestrator of a single declared mission.

User Job

Job to be Done:

When I am hosting a gathering, I want help pulling together everything the occasion requires (food, drinks, the small things that signal care), so I can feel confident, prepared, and energized with my guests instead of exhausted from managing logistics all day.

Situation:

The user is hosting people on a specific date. The guest list and the date are locked in. They are looking at an empty fridge and a mental list that keeps growing.

Struggle:

There is no single source for what hosting actually requires. Wine goes in one app, cheese in another, flowers in a third. The user is context-switching across tabs, comparing options in categories they are

not an expert in, worrying they are forgetting something obvious, and by the time guests arrive they are exhausted before the party has even started.

Desired Progress and Outcome:

The user wants to see one mission with one cart that someone competent has already thought through, so they can stop being the project manager and start being the host. They want to show up to their own party feeling excited rather than depleted, confident that the food is good, the table looks intentional, and nothing critical is missing.

Prioritization

This feature is prioritized first because it is the entry point the rest of the Mission Intelligence roadmap requires. Mission Templates need a place to live. Mission Carts need an anchor to assemble around. Mission Feedback needs a declared mission to evaluate. Mission Memory needs a declared mission to remember. Until users can declare a mission in the first place, nothing else in the roadmap can operate on real data.

Hosting a Saturday gathering is also the right mission to anchor on. It requires multi-merchant orchestration, which is where DoorDash's differentiated logistics network creates the most value, and where failure modes (wrong items, missing substitutions, quality misses) turn high-value users away the fastest. This is the right mission to anchor on because it validates the core thesis of mission-level intelligence, and because users are most likely to delegate repeatedly if the experience works.

The broader roadmap builds from this entry point:

- Capture declared missions through Mission-First Home.
- Use declared missions to power Mission Templates that ops can author and scale.
- Layer in Smart Mission Cart logic that learns from completed missions over time.
- Add Mission and Item Feedback to evaluate cart quality.
- Add Mission-Aware Substitutions that understand what the user is trying to accomplish.
- Eventually create Mission Memory that learns user patterns at the mission level.

The why now is that multi-merchant orchestration is already happening outside DoorDash. Whoever builds the platform layer first wins the structural position of being the orchestrator, not just the delivery layer. One piece of research captured this clearly: users are already operating at the mission level. The platform layer just does not exist yet.

Outcome

Primary outcome:

Capture structured mission intent.

Primary question:

Are users willing to declare a mission instead of browsing stores?

Primary metric:

Percent of users who declare a mission via Mission-First Home, versus falling back to store browsing.

Secondary outcome:

Validate that mission-based shopping is something users actually want.

Secondary question:

Does the mission-first experience deliver on the promise of reducing hosting orchestration load?

Secondary metrics:

Percent of declared missions that complete checkout on a multi-merchant cart. Percent of completed missions rated thumbs-up at the mission level.

Higher-level business outcome:

Increase missions completed on DoorDash, increase multi-merchant order volume, and increase DashPass retention among users who complete two or more party missions. DashPass retention is the real long-term lever, because a user who delegates two hosting missions successfully has already proven they will pay DoorDash to absorb logistics they would have done themselves.

Scope

Included

The prototype should focus on one core feature: a mission declaration entry point on the home screen that routes users into a curated multi-merchant cart.

At the micro-action level, the user can:

- Tap a mission chip on the home screen (dinner, brunch, game day, cocktail night, casual gathering).
- Confirm guest count.
- Confirm date.
- Review the resulting curated multi-merchant cart.
- Swap, add, or remove items in the cart.
- Proceed to a single multi-merchant checkout.
- Dismiss Mission-First Home to fall back to store browsing.

The system should:

- Surface Mission-First Home on app open in place of the store grid.
- Route the mission declaration to the right ops-authored template.
- Scale template quantities by guest count.
- Check merchant availability against the declared date.
- Assemble a multi-merchant cart from the template.

- Log the mission declaration as a structured first-party signal.

This is not a personalized recommendation engine or a generative AI concierge. It is a structured front door that captures mission intent the platform does not have today. This distinction matters because order history only shows what users bought. Mission data shows why they bought it, which is the signal Mission Intelligence requires.

Excluded

At the micro level, the prototype should not include:

- Natural language mission entry.
- ML-driven cart personalization.
- Dietary restriction capture.
- Vibe or theme capture.
- Budget tier selection.
- Per-guest preference capture.
- Conversational AI concierge.
- Mission feedback at the item level.
- Substitution intelligence.
- Mission memory across events.

At the macro level, the prototype should not include the full Mission Intelligence roadmap yet.

That means no Smart Mission Cart with ML, no Mission and Item Feedback, no Mission-Aware Substitutions, no Mission Memory, and no Trust pillar features such as quality guarantees or merchant reliability scoring. Those are later roadmap layers once Mission-First Home has generated enough declared-mission data to make each subsequent feature feel useful and coherent.

User Journey

The feature should appear at the single highest-leverage moment in the hosting workflow: the moment the user decides to host and opens the app.

1. App open

On app open, the user sees Mission-First Home in place of the store grid. The screen leads with mission chips and a fallback link to store browsing. This is the only place where the declare action originates, which keeps the mental model clean and the funnel measurable.

2. Declare flow

After the user taps a mission chip, the flow walks them through guest count and date. Three taps total: chip, count, date. The user then lands in the cart. This is where the mission becomes a structured signal.

3. Cart review

The cart is a multi-merchant view organized by mission, not by store. The user can edit the cart but does not have to. From here they proceed to a single multi-merchant checkout.

4. Fallback at any point

If the user does not want to declare a mission, they can dismiss Mission-First Home and fall back to the store grid at any time. The feature is opt-in by design and should not block users who came to the app for a different reason.

Logic

Eligibility rules

- All users see Mission-First Home on app open during the MVE rollout.
- Mission declaration is optional. Users can dismiss it and fall back to store browsing at any time.
- Only mission types with an ops-authored template are eligible to be declared in the MVE. Five templates exist at launch: dinner, brunch, game day, cocktail night, casual gathering.

Mission declaration states

Each user can have one of three states at any time:

- No active mission. The user has not declared a mission in the current session.
- Active mission. The user has declared a mission and has not yet completed or abandoned it.
- Completed mission. The user has checked out and the mission moves to history.

Mission declarations persist across sessions until the user completes checkout, abandons the mission, or starts a new one. Only one active mission per user at a time.

Cart assembly rules

- The system applies the ops-authored template for the declared mission type and scales quantities by guest count.
- The system checks merchant availability against the declared date. If an item is unavailable, the system substitutes from a pre-approved fallback list. If no fallback is available, the item is dropped and the user is notified.
- The user can swap, add, or remove items at any point before checkout. User edits override template defaults.
- The cart is multi-merchant by default. The user does not check out per store.

Prompting rules

- Mission-First Home is the default home screen but is fully dismissible.
- Once dismissed in a session, it does not re-prompt during that session.
- The store grid is always one tap away.

- Mission declaration never blocks browsing, checkout, or any existing DoorDash flow.

Trust guardrails

- Curated cart contents must clear a quality bar reviewed by ops before each template goes live.
- Item prices and merchant fees must be transparent in the cart view, not surfaced only at checkout.
- If a template assembles a cart that exceeds a reasonable price ceiling for the declared mission and guest count, the system flags it for ops review rather than shipping it to the user.

Trust guardrails matter here because hosting carries social stakes that ordinary shopping does not. A user who gets burned on a hosting mission will not declare one again, and they will not trust the platform with other missions either. The flywheel between Mission Intelligence and Trust runs in both directions.

Measurement guardrail

The first version should not be judged by whether cart quality is perfect. The first question is simpler: are users willing to declare a mission at all? That is why the primary metric is the percent of users who declare a mission via Mission-First Home, not cart quality or mission completion satisfaction. Cart quality matters, but it is a second-order question that only becomes interesting if users declare in the first place.

Week 7 Add ons:

- Edge Cases / Error States
- Acceptance Criteria
- Design Guidelines
- Technical context *[optional - this is relevant for developing the real deal]*
- Implementation guidance *[optional - this is relevant for developing the real deal]*

Edge Cases / Error States:

Mission Entry & Eligibility

- User taps a mission chip that is no longer supported because the template was unpublished after app load.
- User starts a mission flow but closes the app before completing guest count/date selection.
- User attempts to start a second mission while another mission is already active.
- User dismisses Mission-First Home and later expects to return to it within the same session.
- User enters an invalid or unsupported guest count (e.g., zero guests, extremely large party sizes).
- User selects a past date or a date outside merchant scheduling windows.
- User is in a geography where required merchants for a template are unavailable.

Cart Assembly & Inventory

- One or more template items are unavailable for the selected date.
- Fallback substitutions are also unavailable.
- Cart cannot satisfy minimum viability for the mission (e.g., no beverage merchant available for cocktail night).
- Multi-merchant checkout fails because one merchant closes before checkout completion.
- Price spikes or fees push the cart above the acceptable mission price ceiling.
- Quantity scaling logic produces unrealistic item quantities for edge guest counts.
- Merchant inventory changes between cart assembly and checkout.
- Duplicate or conflicting substitutions are added to the cart.
- Delivery windows across merchants do not overlap.

Checkout & Persistence

- User abandons cart and returns later with stale inventory or pricing.
- Active mission persists incorrectly after successful checkout.
- User edits override template defaults and create inconsistent cart logic.
- One merchant order fails during checkout while others succeed.
- Payment succeeds for some merchants but not all.
- Session timeout occurs during mission declaration or checkout.

UX & Trust

- User does not understand that the cart is curated rather than personalized.
- User feels “locked in” and cannot easily return to normal browsing.
- Cart pricing appears unexpectedly high due to fees across multiple merchants.
- User confusion about why items were substituted or removed.
- User perceives recommendations as low quality or socially inappropriate for hosting.
- Accessibility failures on mission chips or checkout flow.

Logging & Data Integrity

- Mission declaration event fails to log, resulting in missing structured intent data.
- Duplicate mission events are logged because of retries or refreshes.
- Mission state becomes desynchronized across devices.
- Analytics fail to distinguish between dismissed users and bounced users.

Acceptance Criteria

Functional Acceptance Criteria

Mission-First Home

- On app open, all eligible users see Mission-First Home instead of the traditional store grid.
- Users can dismiss Mission-First Home in one tap.
- Once dismissed, the experience does not reappear during the same session.
- Users can always access the traditional store browsing experience within one tap.

Mission Declaration Flow

- Users can select one of five launch mission types:

- Dinner
- Brunch
- Game Day
- Cocktail Night
- Casual Gathering
- Users can confirm guest count.
- Users can confirm hosting date.
- The declaration flow is completable within three primary interactions before cart load.
- Only one active mission may exist per user at a time.
- Mission state persists across sessions until checkout completion, abandonment, or replacement.

Cart Assembly

- The system maps the selected mission to the correct ops-authored template.
- Item quantities scale automatically based on guest count.
- Merchant availability is validated against the selected date.
- The system automatically substitutes unavailable items using approved fallback logic.
- If no substitute exists, the item is removed and the user is notified.
- The resulting experience produces a single multi-merchant cart.
- Users can add, remove, or swap items before checkout.
- User edits override template defaults.

Checkout

- Users can complete checkout through a single unified checkout flow.
- Pricing and merchant fees are visible before checkout confirmation.
- Mission completion status is updated after successful checkout.
- Completed missions move into mission history.

Analytics & Measurement

- Every mission declaration is logged as structured first-party mission intent.
- System logs distinguish:
 - Mission declared
 - Mission dismissed
 - Checkout completed
 - Mission abandoned
- Funnel measurement supports tracking:

- Mission declaration rate
- Multi-merchant checkout completion rate
- Mission thumbs-up rating rate

Non-Functional Acceptance Criteria

- Cart assembly latency should feel near-instant to the user.
- Mission flow should not block existing DoorDash browsing flows.
- The feature should degrade gracefully if template or merchant services fail.
- Checkout reliability should match existing DoorDash checkout standards.
- Pricing transparency should be maintained throughout the experience.
- The system should support future extensibility for personalization and mission memory.

Design Guidelines

Product Principles

Mission Over Marketplace

- Organize the experience around the user's hosting goal, not merchant catalogs.
- Reinforce the idea that DoorDash is orchestrating an event, not simply delivering items.

Low Cognitive Load

- Reduce planning anxiety through simple, guided interactions.
- Minimize decisions during declaration.
- Keep the declare flow lightweight and fast.

Trust & Transparency

- Clearly communicate substitutions, fees, and merchant sources.
- Avoid "black box" recommendations.
- Ensure users always feel in control of edits.

Opt-In Experience

- Mission declaration should feel assistive, not coercive.

- Store browsing remains accessible at all times.

UX Guidelines

Home Screen

- Mission chips should be visually prominent and immediately understandable.
- Limit initial choices to prevent decision overload.
- Include a clearly visible fallback link to traditional browsing.
- Maintain familiar DoorDash visual patterns where possible.

Mission Declaration

- Use progressive disclosure:
 1. Mission type
 2. Guest count
 3. Date
- Avoid unnecessary form fields.
- Use defaults and smart presets where appropriate.
- Optimize for mobile one-handed interactions.

Cart Experience

- Group items by mission purpose rather than merchant.
- Surface substitutions inline with explanations.
- Make editing frictionless.
- Show pricing transparency throughout the flow.
- Highlight delivery coordination clearly.

Error Handling

- Errors should be actionable and non-blocking.
- Provide clear recovery paths.
- Avoid technical language.
- Preserve user progress whenever possible.

Accessibility

- Mission chips and CTAs should meet touch target requirements.
- Support screen readers and semantic labeling.
- Ensure sufficient contrast ratios.

- Avoid reliance on color alone for meaning.

Technical Context

System Architecture Context

The prototype introduces a new orchestration layer on top of the existing DoorDash commerce platform.

The experience requires coordination across:

- Front-end mission declaration flows
- Template orchestration services
- Merchant inventory systems
- Cart assembly services
- Checkout services
- Analytics and event pipelines

The prototype is intentionally rules-based rather than AI-driven.

Core Data Objects

Mission

Represents the declared hosting intent.

Suggested fields:

- Mission ID
- User ID
- Mission type
- Guest count
- Event date
- Mission state
- Created timestamp
- Updated timestamp

Mission Template

Ops-authored structured configuration for each mission.

Suggested fields:

- Template ID
- Mission type
- Item groups
- Quantity scaling rules
- Approved substitutions
- Price ceiling
- Supported regions

Mission Cart

Generated multi-merchant cart tied to a mission.

Suggested fields:

- Cart ID
- Mission ID
- Merchant IDs
- Item list
- Substitution metadata
- Delivery windows
- Pricing summary

State Management

Mission States

- No Active Mission
- Active Mission
- Completed Mission
- Abandoned Mission

Session Rules

- One active mission per user.
- Mission persists across sessions.
- Dismissal suppresses prompts only for the current session.

Dependencies

Internal Dependencies

- Existing cart infrastructure
- Existing checkout infrastructure
- Merchant inventory APIs
- Pricing and fee services
- User session management
- Event logging/analytics platform

Operational Dependencies

- Ops-authored templates
- Approved substitution lists
- Quality review workflows
- Merchant availability coverage

Technical Risks

- Multi-merchant synchronization complexity.
- Inventory volatility across merchants.
- Cross-merchant delivery coordination.
- Latency introduced by template assembly.
- Analytics gaps in mission attribution.
- Increased checkout failure points.
- Scalability of rules-based templates.

Implementation Guidance

Phase 1: Foundation

Build Mission Declaration Flow

Implement:

- Mission-first landing screen
- Mission chip selection
- Guest count selector
- Date selector
- Dismiss flow

- State persistence

Focus on:

- Fast interaction speed
- Minimal friction
- Reliable analytics capture

Success condition: Users can reliably declare a mission and reach a generated cart.

Phase 2: Template & Cart Orchestration

Build Rules-Based Template Engine

Implement:

- Template lookup by mission type
- Quantity scaling rules
- Merchant availability checks
- Fallback substitution logic
- Multi-merchant cart assembly

Avoid:

- Personalization logic
- ML ranking
- Natural language parsing

Success condition: System consistently generates viable carts for supported missions.

Phase 3: Checkout Integration

Extend Existing Checkout Infrastructure

Implement:

- Unified multi-merchant checkout
- Transparent fee breakdowns
- Mission completion state transitions
- Cart persistence

Focus on:

- Reliability
- Delivery coordination clarity
- Graceful degradation on merchant failure

Success condition: Users can complete a full mission purchase flow end-to-end.

Phase 4: Analytics & Experimentation

Instrument Funnel Metrics

Track:

- Impression rate
- Dismissal rate
- Mission declaration rate
- Cart edit frequency
- Checkout completion rate
- Mission abandonment rate
- Mission satisfaction feedback

Ensure:

- Structured mission intent is queryable.
- Events are deduplicated.
- Funnel stages are attributable.

Success condition: Product teams can measure whether users are willing to declare missions.

Recommended Engineering Approach

Keep the System Deterministic

For the MVE:

- Use rules-based templates.
- Keep orchestration logic explicit.
- Prioritize operational quality over intelligence.

This reduces:

- Debugging complexity

- User unpredictability
- Trust failures
- Experiment ambiguity

Suggested Rollout Strategy

Controlled Rollout

- Start with a limited geography.
- Limit to high-coverage merchants.
- Roll out to a percentage of users.
- Monitor checkout reliability closely.

Operational Review Loop

Before enabling a template:

- Ops validates cart quality.
- Pricing ceiling is reviewed.
- Delivery coordination is tested.
- Substitution behavior is verified.

Long-Term Extensibility

The implementation should preserve extensibility for future roadmap layers:

- Mission memory
- Personalized mission carts
- ML ranking
- Conversational mission planning
- Dietary constraints
- Trust scoring
- Mission-aware substitutions

To support future expansion:

- Keep mission intent structured.
- Maintain clean event schemas.
- Separate orchestration logic from presentation.
- Design templates as configurable data objects rather than hardcoded flows.

